Other exercises tested leadership skills. Sleep-deprivation techniques were used as a training tool. The link between playing cricket for your country and being woken at 2 a.m. to do hard, physical work, carrying bricks across a forest, may be tenuous but it has a scientific basis, in the response of the brain to shared experiences.

The programme built upon the collective experience of visiting the concentration camp at Dachau before the 2009 Ashes. That had reinforced the power of perspective. No one emerges untouched from such a profound occurrence. It preys on the mind and challenges the conscience. I began to understand the team-building theory, that trust is enhanced when you see those close to you being pushed to the edge, physically and psychologically.

It was enriching in hindsight. Hardship bred a renewed sense of what could be achieved together. People reminisced fondly about carrying out menial tasks in the pouring rain at three in the morning. Jimmy Anderson's broken rib, sustained in a boxing match, entered dressing-room legend. We were ready for the relative sanity of an Ashes tour in Australia …